# Using WebDAV

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# Agenda

- What is WebDAV?
- Benefits
- Basic Scenarios
- Technical Summary
- WebDAV Software
- Using WebDAV
- Wrap up



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# What is WebDAV?

- Web-Based Distributed Authoring and Versioning "DAV" is the usual short form
- Goal: enable **interoperability** of tools for distributed web authoring
- Turns the web into a *writable* medium
- Applies to all kinds of content - not just HTML and images
- Based on extensions to HTTP
- Uses XML for properties, control, status
- RFC 2518 (Core) and RFC 3253 (DeltaV)



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# Benefits

- User benefits
  - Document metadata available
  - More intelligent "directory" listings
- Author benefits
  - Standard way to place content on the server
  - Move/copy the content as needed
  - Tag the content with metadata
  - Overwrite protection in group scenarios
  - Versioning of documents and change sets



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# Benefits (cont.)

- Administrator benefits
  - All interaction via the protocol
  - Divorces local system layout, configuration, and structure from the author's conceptual space
  - HTTP authentication rather than system accounts
- Technical benefits for developers
  - Infrastructure: old and new
  - Replacement protocol



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# Basic Scenarios

- Departmental Server
- Collaborative publishing
- Web Hosting at an ISP
- Software development
- *many more...*



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# Technical Summary

- Layered on HTTP/1.1 using its extension facilities
- New methods for example: `COPY`, `MKCOL`, `PROPFIND`, `CHECKOUT`
- New headers
- Some slight changes to existing methods' semantics
- RFC 2518 ("core"): pretty straight-forward
- RFC 3253 (versioning): complex



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# Existing Infrastructure

- All the benefits of HTTP
- Strong authentication
- Encryption
- Proxy/firewall navigation
- Worldwide deployment
- Huge talent pool, numerous tools, apps, etc



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# WebDAV Software - Clients

- Joe Orton: cadaver, sitecopy, Neon
- SkunkDAV, DAV Explorer
- Twingle
- APIs: Python, Perl, C, Java
- Commercial software: Microsoft, Adobe, Macromedia, etc



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# WebDAV Software - Operating Sytems

- MacOS X
- Windows XP
- GNOME VFS
- KDE "kio"
- DAVFS / DAVFS2

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# WebDAV Software - Servers

- Apache 2.0 and Apache 1.3/mod_dav
- Zope
- Tomcat, Jakarta Slide
- Bunches of commercial servers



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# Using WebDAV

- What kind of content are you managing?
- Do you have an existing workflow pattern?
- What users are involved? Where are they located?
- What platforms are in use? Existing tools? Technical users?



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# Example: Departmental Server

- Department of 20 staff
- Set up a private WebDAV-enabled web server
- Use the web server instead of a file server
- Better navigation, overviews, searching, offsite linking, etc
- Can easily link into web-based applications
- Authors place and modify documents right into the URL space
- Can update summaries, navigation, and other discovery pages
- Web server admin can partition space based on roles



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# Example: Collaborative Publishing

- Almost exactly like the departmental server example
- Some users happen to be remote
- Web server admin may structure the network and authentication a bit differently, but this has no real effect on users
- Configure the server to be a bit stricter with permissions



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# Example: Web Hosting at an ISP

- Users are provided web pages they can edit
- Much more secure than SSH-based or FTP-based page publishing since local/system accounts are not required
- Easier to manage the underlying directory structures since users never see them



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# Example: Software Development

- The versioning aspect of WebDAV comes into play
- Built in remotability, authentication, authorization, etc
- Browsing and down-level support ("autoversioning") for non-DeltaV clients
- Check out Subversion

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# Wrap up

- Interoperability
- Expansion of capability
- Easy -- it is just HTTP
- Lots of tools
- Satisfies many common scenarios

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